Table 4.3 Comparison of conservative and non-conservative forces

S.No	Conservative forces	Non-conservative forces
1.	Work done is independent of the path	Work done depends upon the path
2.	Work done in a round trip is zero	Work done in a round trip is not zero
3	Total energy remains constant	Energy is dissipated as heat energy
4	Work done is completely recoverable	Work done is not completely recoverable.
5	Force is the negative gradient of potential energy	No such relation exists.

Non-conservative force

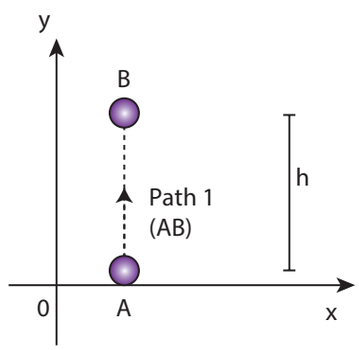
A force is said to be non-conservative if the work done by or against the force in moving a body depends upon the path between the initial and final positions. This means that the value of work done is different in different paths.

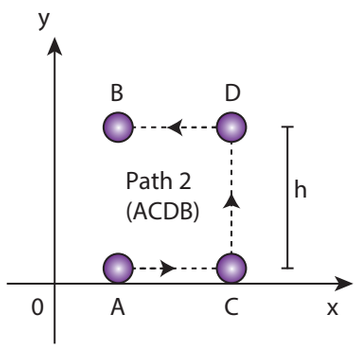
1. Frictional forces are non-conservative forces as the work done against friction depends on the length of the path moved by the body.
2. The force due to air resistance, viscous force are also non-conservative forces as the work done by or against these forces depends upon the velocity of motion.

The properties of conservative and non-conservative forces are summarized in the Table 4.3.

EXAMPLE 4.11

Compute the work done by the gravitational force for the following cases





Solution

Force $\vec{F} = mg\left(-\hat{j}\right) = -mg\hat{j}$

Displacement vector $d\vec{r} = dx\,\hat{i} + dy\,\hat{j}$

(As the displacement is in two dimension; unit vectors $\hat{i}$ and $\hat{j}$ are used)

(a) Since the motion is only vertical, horizontal displacement component dx is zero. Hence, work done by the force along path 1 (of distance h).

$$W_{\text{path 1}} = \int_A^B \vec{F}.d\vec{r} = \int_A^B \left(-mg\hat{j}\right).\left(dy\,\hat{j}\right)$$

$$= -mg\int_0^h dy = -mgh$$

Total work done for path 2 is

$$W_{\text{path 2}} = \int_A^B \vec{F}.d\vec{r} = \int_A^C \vec{F}.d\vec{r} + \int_C^D \vec{F}.d\vec{r} + \int_D^B \vec{F}.d\vec{r}$$

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